



Beneath a Crimson Banner

A Total War: Three Kingdoms Modlist for v1.7.2

Three Waves • Three Campaigns • One Destiny

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Wave 0 — The Warlord's First Steps

Roleplaying Background

The Han dynasty crumbles. Yellow Turban rebels burn the countryside, and warlords across the land sharpen their blades. You are not yet among them — you are a minor official, a displaced captain, or a wandering scholar. The world is vast and dangerous. Every decision matters.

Your goal: survive. Learn the land. Build a following.

Game Setup

Setting	Choice
Difficulty	Normal
Campaign	Mandate of Heaven / Rise of the Warlords (any)
Faction	Any recommended starter faction (e.g., Cao Cao, Sun Jian, Liu Bei)
Turn Timer	Unlimited
Battle Time Limit	60 min

Mods in This Wave

This wave uses only UI improvements and quality-of-life mods. No gameplay overhauls. This is the vanilla experience — polished.

Choosing Your Faction

Your starting faction defines your campaign. Each plays radically differently.

Starter Factions (Recommended for First Campaign)

Faction	Playstyle	Difficulty	Why Start Here
Liu Bei	Diplomacy, defensive, brotherhood	Easy	Strongest starting generals (Guan Yu, Zhang Fei). Safe northeastern start. Best for learning.
Sun Jian	Economy, navy, southern expansion	Easy	Richest starting province. Protected south flank. Strong ranged units. Forgiving economy.
Cao Cao	Manipulation, vassals, central China	Medium	Best diplomatic tools. Access to unique “Credibility” resource. Starts in the middle of everything — more action, more danger.

Intermediate Factions (After Your First Win)

Faction	Playstyle	Why Play Them
Gongsun Zan	Cavalry blitz, northern aggression	Best cavalry faction. White Horse Fellows are devastating. Fast expansion.
Yuan Shao	Vassal swarm, heavy infantry	Can vassalize without war. Massive army count. Plays tall through subordinates.
Sun Ce	Aggressive expansion, young heroes	Sun Ce's "Conqueror" bonuses reward rapid war. Heir to Sun Jian's southern base.
Liu Biao	Defensive, economic turtle	Starts huge but fragmented. Teaches defensive campaign management.

Advanced Factions (For Experienced Players)

Faction	Playstyle	Challenge
Dong Zhuo	Aggression, terror	Everyone hates you from turn 1. Constant war. Lu Bu is a one-man army.
Ma Teng	Horse nomads, western frontier	Unique cavalry roster. Remote start, slow to expand.
Kong Rong	Trade empire, diplomatic	Weak military, strong economy. Must buy allies and out-earn enemies.
Yellow Turban	Religious horde, unique mechanics	Completely different tech tree, units, and government. Feels like a different game.
Nanman	Jungle warfare, monsters	DLC-locked. Elephant units. Different building and reform systems.

DLC Factions

DLC	Factions Added
Yellow Turban Rebellion	He Yi, Gong Du, Huang Shao — different mechanics entirely
Eight Princes	Sima family — eight unique factions in a later time period
Mandate of Heaven	Liu Hong (Han Emperor) — play as the Han trying to hold China together
A World Betrayed	Lu Bu, Yan Baihu — start as roaming forces
Fates Divided	Liu Yan, Yuan Shu — new start positions and faction mechanics
Nanman	Meng Huo, Zhu Rong, and others — jungle factions with unique units

Not sure? Start as **Liu Bei** on Normal. If you prefer naval strength and trade, choose **Sun Jian** instead. Save Cao Cao for your second campaign.

How to Use This Guide

Read 02-how-to-play.md for a complete beginner's guide to the game's systems. The mod list above is installed via TW Mod Manager — see setup-installation-guide.md for instructions.

Mod List

1.7.2 Bug Fix by Community

v1.7.2

QOL

Community bug fix compilation fixing over 149 bugs in v1.7.2. Essential compatibility and stability fixes for campaign, battles, characters, and mechanics.

⚠ **Conflict:** Radiums Total War Mod → Not compatible — Radiums includes its own bug fixes

⚠ **Conflict:** TROM → Not compatible — TROM has 1.7.2 Bug Fix built-in

⚠ **Conflict:** UAD → Not compatible — UAD has 1.7.2 Bug Fix built-in

Does not require a new campaign. Works with most content/graphics mods. Do NOT use with total overhauls that include their own bug fixes.

Improved Campaign Map Performance by kailash

v1.0.0

QOL

Optimizes campaign map rendering for significantly improved framerates. Reduces stutter and lag on the campaign map without visual quality loss.

Compatible with all mods. Simple performance tweak with no gameplay changes.

Overlay Map Alternate (English) by kailash

v1.0.0

UI

English-language campaign map overlay with clearer province borders, settlement type indicators, and improved readability. Makes the map easier to navigate.

Cosmetic UI change only. Works with all mods.

Enhanced Battle Camera by Petellius

v1.0.0

UI

Unlocks the battle camera allowing extended zoom out, closer zoom in, and removes camera boundary restrictions. Gives full control over battlefield views.

Totally cosmetic. Does not affect gameplay balance.

Ink Selection Markers

by Little_Fighter

v1.0.0

UI

Ink-brush styled unit selection markers replacing vanilla circles. Far more visible and thematically appropriate for the Three Kingdoms setting.

Visual UI enhancement only. Compatible with all mods.

A Complete Guide to Total War: Three Kingdoms

The Campaign Map

The campaign map is your empire. Everything — armies, cities, trade, characters — lives on this single screen. Understanding how it works is the foundation of every campaign.

Commanderies, Settlements & Resources

China is divided into **commanderies** — the equivalent of provinces. Each commandery contains a **capital** (the main city) and one or more **resource settlements** (smaller towns producing copper, iron, horses, fish, or timber).

Resource settlements are why you go to war. Copper reduces construction costs across your entire faction. Iron unlocks better infantry units. Horses unlock better cavalry. A commandery with a horse pasture is worth fighting for; a barren plateau is not. Look at the resource icon next to each settlement before you decide where to expand — it tells you exactly what you're gaining.

Each commandery also has a **population** value. As population grows, you can upgrade buildings to higher tiers. Population grows fastest with high food surplus and high public order. Starvation and unrest stop growth completely.

Build order that works for every commandery: 1. **Farm first** — always. Food surplus is non-negotiable. Without it you get starvation, unrest, and revolts. 2. **Income building second** — market for commerce, workshop for industry. Match it to the commandery's resources (e.g., a port commandery wants a trade port, not a workshop). 3. **Public order third** — temple, Confucian school, or garrison. Corruption and expansion generate unrest. You need a counter before the unrest arrives, not after.

Characters

Characters are the most important resource in Three Kingdoms. A level-6 Vanguard general with good traits is worth more than an entire army. Lose your loyal generals because of mismanagement and your campaign will fall apart whether you notice it or not.

Every character has a **class** (Commander, Vanguard, Champion, Strategist, Sentinel), a **satisfaction** score, and a set of **traits** earned through gameplay. Satisfaction is loyalty — drop below 0 and the character conspires against you or defects to another faction. Several things affect satisfaction:

- **Court position** — the single most powerful satisfaction tool. Every character wants a title. Give one to anyone with low satisfaction.
- **Salary** — increases automatically with rank. You can raise it manually but it costs gold.
- **Ancillaries** — weapons, armour, and accessories. Each gives +2–5 satisfaction on top of their stat bonuses. Give your spare items to borderline-loyal characters.
- **Events and dilemmas** — choices you make in story events can swing satisfaction by +/-20 for specific characters. Think before you pick a side.
- **Idleness** — characters gain a “Complacent” trait if left idle for many turns, which gives a permanent satisfaction penalty. Never leave a good general doing nothing.

You manage characters through several systems:

- **Assignments** let you dispatch characters to settlements for temporary bonuses (food, commerce, satisfaction, etc.). This is how you keep idle characters useful without paying them a court position.

- **Administrators** are assigned to individual commanderies. They reduce corruption and provide bonuses based on their traits. A Sentinel administrator in a wealthy province can double its income.
- **Court positions** are faction-level titles (Heir, Prime Minister, Chancellor, etc.) that grant powerful faction-wide bonuses. The Prime Minister's "+satisfaction to all" trait can single-handedly stabilise a large empire.
- **The family tree** tracks your faction leader, their spouse, children, and adopted members. Family members are permanently loyal. Use adoption (available through character events) to permanently secure talented but disloyal outsiders.

Government & Reforms

The **reforms tree** is Three Kingdoms' technology system. Unlike a traditional tech tree, reforms unlock in turns — each reform takes 5 turns to research. This means you can't rush a military advantage; you need to plan your research path early and commit.

Each reform gives a permanent faction-wide bonus. The tree is divided into branches (military, economy, administration, commerce) and you typically want to spread points across branches rather than going deep in one. However:

- **Governance reforms** (purple branch) reduce corruption and boost satisfaction. These scale with empire size — the bigger you get, the more valuable they become.
- **Commerce reforms** (green branch) boost income and trade. These compound over time — invest early and the returns accumulate across the entire campaign.
- **Military reforms** unlock better units and general abilities. Important, but don't neglect economy for them. A tier-3 economy can fund tier-2 armies; a tier-3 army with tier-1 economy runs out of gold by turn 30.

Government type determines which court positions are available and how your satisfaction system works. Changing government type is expensive (causes a -15 satisfaction penalty to everyone for several turns) so choose one that fits your playstyle and stick with it.

Diplomacy

Diplomacy in Three Kingdoms is not a side system. It is your primary defence and your most efficient weapon. A well-negotiated peace saves you an army. A marriage alliance can flip a neutral neighbour into a loyal ally. A food-for-gold trade deal funds an entire building queue.

Every diplomatic action depends on **relations** — a score between -100 and +100 that represents how much that faction likes you. Relations build through trade, shared enemies, gifts, and marriage. They decay through war, broken promises, and proximity (neighbouring factions naturally distrust each other).

Here is what each diplomatic tool actually does and when to use it:

- **Trade agreement** — requires a connected route (roads, ports, or shared borders leading to each other's capitals). Generates gold per turn. Sign with everyone who'll accept. The gold adds up fast and, critically, trade improves relations over time.
- **Non-aggression pact** — the most important defensive tool. An NAP prevents a faction from declaring war on you. Sign them with neighbours you don't plan to fight for the next 30 turns. Breaking an NAP damages your reliability.
- **Military access** — lets allies move through your territory. Don't give it out unless you genuinely need their army on your land. Access is often used as a prelude to invasion by untrustworthy AI.

- **Coalition** — a defensive alliance of multiple factions. If anyone attacks a coalition member, all members join the war. This is the best deterrent in the game. Form coalitions early with your neighbours.
- **Military alliance** — an offensive and defensive pact. You join all of their wars (and they join yours). Military alliances are dangerous — the AI will drag you into wars you don't want. Use sparingly.
- **Marriage** — binds two families. Between your faction and another, it's an alliance-level bond. Within your faction, marrying a character into your family makes them permanently loyal.
- **Vassalage** — subjugates another faction. They pay you tribute, can't declare war independently, and must join your wars. Use this instead of conquering — a vassal is a buffer state that generates gold without adding to your corruption or public order burden.

Food-for-money deals deserve special mention. Many AI factions run food deficits. You can trade excess food for lump sums of gold or per-turn income. This is the easiest way to generate early-game cash. Offer 10-20 food per turn for 500-1000 gold to any faction with low reserves.

Reliability is your most fragile diplomatic stat. It drops every time you break a treaty, attack an ally, or declare war within a truce cooldown. Low reliability makes every other faction refuse to deal with you — they will extort you, refuse trade, and declare opportunistic wars. Never break a treaty unless absolutely necessary. Never declare war on an ally unless you've already wrecked that campaign and need to salvage it.

Battles

Unit Matchups (The Combat Triangle)

Every unit in Three Kingdoms fits into a rock-paper-scissors system. Winning battles is about bringing the right counter to each enemy unit.

Your Unit	Beats	Loses To	Strategy
Spear Infantry	Cavalry	Shock Infantry, Missiles	Frontline anchor. Hold position, brace against charges.
Sword Infantry	Shock Infantry	Missiles, Cavalry	Flexible line. Decent in melee, weak to cavalry flanking.
Shock Infantry	Spear Infantry	Sword Infantry, Missiles	Two-handed weapons, armour-piercing. Kill armoured targets.
Cavalry (Melee)	Missiles, Ranged	Spear Infantry	Flanking and pursuit. Never charge spears head-on.
Cavalry (Shock)	Missiles, Ranged	Spear Infantry	Cycle charge: charge, withdraw, charge again. Massive impact.
Missile Infantry	Spear/Sword Infantry	Cavalry	Protect with frontline. Fire into enemy flanks for morale damage.
Artillery	Dense formations, Towers	Cavalry	Siege-breaking. Use on enemy blobs and gate towers.

The golden rule: Spear holds the line, cavalry flanks, missiles kill from safety, shock infantry breaks through.

Formations & When to Use Them

Formation	Use When	Effect
Shield Wall	Expecting frontal missile fire	+100% shield block chance, -speed
Spear Wall	Expecting cavalry charge	Massive charge negation, anti-large bonus
Diamond	Marching through danger	+50% speed, -defence — move through a kill zone
Wedge	Cavalry breakthrough	Charge bonus increased, armour reduced
Testudo	Approaching archer towers	Blocks overhead missiles
Loose	Under artillery fire	Reduces AoE damage, -melee defence
Circle	Surrounded	360-degree defence, no movement

Terrain & Positioning

Terrain	Effect	How to Use
High Ground	+10% missile damage, +5 melee damage, morale bonus	Always take the hill before engaging.
Forest	Blocks line of sight, -20% missile accuracy	Hide ambush units. Negates enemy archers.
River	Slows movement, exhausts units	Defend the far bank. Attack while enemy is crossing.
Choke Point	Numerical advantage negated	Small elite force can hold against a much larger army.
Settlement Walls	Garrison missile bonus, gate defence	Use towers to weaken attackers before sallying out.
Bridge	Forces 1v1 engagements	Best defensive position in the game.

How to win a land battle: 1. **Pre-battle:** Deploy on high ground. Put spears in front, missiles behind, cavalry on flanks. 2. **Engagement:** Let enemy come to you (defensive advantage). Spear wall vs cavalry. Shield wall vs missiles. 3. **Flank:** Once lines are engaged, send cavalry around the side. Charge into the enemy's rear — this causes massive morale damage and routes units instantly. 4. **General snipe:** Focus missiles on the enemy general. If the general dies, nearby units take huge morale penalties. 5. **Cleanup:** Once enemy morale breaks, pursue with cavalry. A routing unit that escapes can fight again — don't let them.

Morale Mechanics

Morale is the most important stat in Total War. A high-stat unit with broken morale is useless.

Factor	Effect on Morale
General nearby	+morale aura (radius increases with rank)
General killed	Massive morale penalty to nearby units
Flanked (side hit)	Moderate morale damage
Rear charge	Severe morale damage (1 charge can route a unit)
Routing allies nearby	Cascading morale loss
Exhaustion	Significant morale penalty
On fire	Morale penalty + attrition
Heroic victory	Permanent morale buff for that army

To make enemies route: Kill/injure their general, flank with cavalry, then focus missiles on the wavering unit. Wavering → routing → chain route.

General Classes on the Battlefield

Class	Role	Key Ability
Commander	Army morale anchor	“+satisfaction” aura, army replenishment
Vanguard	Cavalry commander	Charge bonus, cavalry buffs
Champion	Duelist, infantry killer	Personal duelling skills, high melee damage
Strategist	Ranged support, formations	Fire arrows, smoke screen, night battles
Sentinel	Defensive line, garrison buff	Melee defence, garrison bonuses

In Romance mode generals are superheroes — they can single-handedly kill hundreds of troops. Use them aggressively but don’t let them get surrounded. **In Records mode** generals are bodyguard units (heavy cavalry). Powerful but mortal — use as elite cavalry, not invincible heroes.

Army Composition Templates

Balanced (recommended for learning): - 2 Spear Infantry (frontline anchor) - 2 Sword/Shock Infantry (melee line) - 2 Ji Militia (anti-cavalry reserve) - 2 Archer Militia (ranged damage) - 2 Jian Sword Cavalry or Sabre Cavalry (flanking) - General retinues fill the rest

Cavalry Focus (aggressive): - 2 Spear Infantry (minimal frontline) - 4 Cavalry units (mix of shock and melee) - 2 Archers (pin the enemy) - Everything in general retinues as cavalry

Defensive (counter-attack): - 4 Spear Infantry (Shield Wall) - 4 Archers/Crossbows (behind the wall) - 2 Cavalry (chase routing units) - 1 Strategist general (fire arrows, formations)

Siege Tactics

Attacking: 1. **Scout** — check which walls have towers. Destroy towers with artillery before advancing. 2. **Breach** — use trebuchets to open wall sections. Send shock infantry through the breach. 3. **Multiple fronts** — attack two walls simultaneously. The AI splits its garrison. 4. **Ladders** — cheap but costly (your climbing units take heavy losses). Use ladders only on weakly-defended walls. 5. **Gate** — battering ram opens the gate. Your cavalry floods in. Rush the capture point. 6. **Victory** — secure the centre square. The garrison surrenders once you hold it.

Defending: 1. **Towers first** — the AI will target your towers. Repair them between assaults. 2.

Burning oil — gates have oil that incinerates attackers. Save it for elite units. 3. **Sally out** — if the enemy has no siege engines, attack them outside the walls with your garrison + relief army. 4.

Attrition — if outnumbered, let the enemy starve. Disease and desertion weaken them over time.

Espionage

Espionage is Three Kingdoms’ invisible weapon. A single well-placed spy can dismantle an empire more efficiently than an army. The system works by sending your characters undercover into enemy factions.

To embed a spy: select any character you can assign, choose “Spy,” and pick a target faction. The character disappears from your roster and appears in the target faction’s court. From that point, they operate independently — building cover, gathering intelligence, and eventually performing actions against the host.

Building cover: Every spy has a “cover” rating. Higher cover means the enemy doesn’t suspect them. Gain cover by performing mundane actions — revealing the faction’s army positions,

reporting on their income, or simply waiting. Each action has a risk percentage; the riskier the action, the more cover it burns.

Actions available: - **Reveal army positions** (low risk) — simple and safe. Good for building cover. - **Sabotage buildings** (medium risk) — damages an enemy settlement's buildings. Slows their economy. - **Steal technologies** (medium risk) — you gain a reform for free. Huge value. - **Assassinate a character** (high risk) — kills a targeted character. Use against their faction leader or a dangerous general about to attack you. - **Incite rebellion** (extreme risk) — spawns a rebel army in the target province. Can cripple an enemy's backline.

Your own counter-intelligence: The AI uses spies against you too. Assign a high-cunning character as an administrator in each commandery — they will reveal enemy spies operating in that region. If you suddenly have public order problems in a stable province or can't see where an enemy army is moving, you likely have an enemy spy.

A spy who becomes the enemy faction leader (through assassination and political maneuvering) can choose to reveal themselves and immediately absorb the entire faction into yours. This takes 50+ turns of careful work but it's the most efficient way to win in the entire game.

Economy

Your economy is a triangle: **food**, **income**, and **public order**. You cannot neglect any of the three without the triangle collapsing. Every building and reform decision should be evaluated against all three.

Food is the foundation. Each army consumes food. Each settlement with a population above 0 consumes food. Running a food deficit causes starvation, which tanks public order and prevents population growth. The minimum safe food surplus is +5. As you expand, aim for +10–20 to buffer against sudden consumption spikes (like recruiting a new general).

Income comes from three sources: - **Commerce** — trade agreements and market buildings. Scales with trade routes. Best for coastal and border factions. - **Industry** — workshops and ports. Steady, reliable, doesn't need external trade partners. Best for isolated factions. - **Taxation** — your ongoing income from owned settlements, adjusted by your tax rate. Higher taxes = more income but slower population growth and lower public order. Keep the tax rate at normal unless you're in crisis.

Corruption is the silent killer of large empires. Every commandery beyond your first adds a corruption percentage that eats into income. An empire of 10 commanderies may lose 30–50% of all income to corruption. Reduce it with: - Assigning administrators (each admin reduces corruption in their commandery) - Reforms in the Governance tree (purple branch) - Buildings that reduce corruption (state workshops, granaries) - Characters with the "Honest" or "Incorruptible" trait

Trade multiplies your income but requires infrastructure. To trade with a faction you need a connected road or sea route from your capital to theirs. Build roads in every commandery. Upgrade your capital's trade port if coastal. Each trade agreement you sign increases the value of your market buildings.

Victory Conditions

Three Kingdoms has a layered victory system. You don't need to paint the entire map to win.

Short campaign: Control X territories (depends on faction) and achieve a prestige milestone. Typically achievable by turn 80–100. A good stopping point for your first campaign after learning the fundamentals.

Long campaign: Control three key commanderies (the capitals of the three historical kingdoms). Takes 120–180 turns. This is the “real” campaign — you’ll experience the full arc from minor warlord to emperor.

The Three Kingdoms phase triggers when any three factions reach King or Emperor prestige level. At this point, the game’s diplomatic landscape freezes — the three kingdoms become permanent rivals. Victory comes from conquering or vassalising both rival capitals.

Prestige is the hidden meter driving victory progression. Every settlement captured, battle won, and reform researched adds prestige. Reaching certain prestige thresholds unlocks kingdom/emperor status and triggers new campaign phases. Focus on steady prestige gain rather than rushing — declaring emperor too early before your armies are ready invites a coalition against you.

Turn Checklist (Every Turn)

Before ending each turn, run through these six checks. They take 15 seconds and prevent 90% of campaign-altering mistakes.

1. **Food** — Is your surplus above +5? If not, cancel a building queue and start a farm. Do not end the turn with a deficit.
2. **Characters** — Is anyone below 60 satisfaction? Give them an ancillary, a court position, or an assignment. Scroll the full character list every turn — don’t just check the top screen.
3. **Armies** — Are all your armies doing something? An idle army is an army costing you upkeep for nothing. Replenish in a settlement, move toward a target, or recruit.
4. **Diplomacy** — Are your trade slots full? Check every faction you’ve met — if “Trade: Accept” is green, send the deal. Missing trade agreements is missing free gold.
5. **Buildings** — Is there an empty building slot? Start something. An empty slot earns zero gold and produces zero food. Even a tier-1 farm is better than an empty lot.
6. **Spies** — If you have no spy in play, send one. Embed them in your most threatening neighbour’s court. Building cover takes time — start now.

Zero to Master Training Path

Phase 0: Setup & Mindset

Goal: Start correctly and avoid common beginner traps.

- **Records vs Romance:** Records mode for more realistic battles; Romance for cinematic hero duels. Both are valid — try both.
- **Recommended first faction:** Liu Bei (strong generals + diplomacy) or Sun Jian (safer southern start).
- **Difficulty:** Start on Normal or Hard. Skip Legendary until you’ve completed all waves.
- **Tutorials:** Turn on in-game tooltips and watch the official Total War Academy videos (linked in main menu).

Key mindset: This is a game of characters + diplomacy + economy, not just battles.

Phase 1: Core Fundamentals

Goal: Understand the basic loop and survive the early game.

Must-Learn Mechanics

- **Commanderies & Settlements** — Every commandery has a capital plus resource settlements. Food and money are the foundation of everything.
- **Characters** — Five classes: Commander, Vanguard, Champion, Strategist, Sentinel. Each has unique roles on the battlefield and in administration.

- **Assignments** — Put characters as Administrators, in Court positions, or as Spies. Never leave good characters idle.
- **Armies** — 3 generals max per army (with retainues). Learn the difference between Militia and Professional units.
- **Basic Diplomacy** — Trade agreements, non-aggression pacts, and coalitions. Food-for-money deals are your best friend early.

Training Exercises

1. Play one full campaign as Liu Bei or Sun Jian focusing only on economy and not over-expanding.
2. Manually fight every battle for the first 30-40 turns so you learn unit strengths.
3. Never auto-resolve important battles until you understand why you win or lose.

Success criteria: Reach turn 50-60 without going bankrupt or being destroyed. Understand why food surplus matters.

First 20 Turns — Liu Bei Campaign Guide

This guide walks you through the first 20 turns as **Liu Bei** on **Normal** difficulty. Liu Bei starts in the northeast with strong generals (Guan Yu, Zhang Fei) and excellent diplomatic options — the ideal learning faction.

Turn 1

Diplomacy

- Send a **Trade Agreement** offer to every faction you've met (Gongsun Zan, Han Sui, Kong Rong, etc.). Accept any that come back. Trade income is small early but compounds.
- Check if any faction will give you money for food. Offer 10-20 food per turn for a lump sum. Use that gold to build.

Army

- Merge damaged units. Guan Yu and Zhang Fei start with good retainues — keep them together.
- Move your main army toward **Dong Commandery** (the settlement just south). Do not attack yet — get into position.

Buildings

- **Commandery capital (Pingyuan):** Build the first tier of a **Farm** (food production) or **Market** (income). Prioritize food if you're at or below 0 surplus.

Characters

- Check your court. Assign any idle characters as **Assignments** — “+10 satisfaction” assignments on your faction leader or heir prevent loyalty problems.
- Set your heir if one isn't assigned. Liu Bei as faction leader, Guan Yu as heir is a strong start.

Turn 2

Army

- Continue moving toward Dong Commandery. If it's unguarded, you can take it next turn without a fight (AI will usually retreat).
- Recruit 1-2 militia units in Pingyuan if you have spare income. Ji Militia (spear) are cheap and effective.

Diplomacy

- Check for **Non-Aggression Pacts** with your neighbors. Gongsun Zan to the north is a useful friend — he'll occupy Yuan Shao's attention.
- Offer NAPs for free or for a small payment. Most factions will accept early on.

Buildings

- If you built a farm last turn, start a **Market** or **Workshop** in your capital now. Diversify income.
- Build a **Road** in your capital commandery. Roads unlock trade routes and speed up army movement.

Turn 3-5: Secure Your First Province

Conquest

- Attack Dong Commandery. If the enemy army is nearby, fight manually — you outnumber them with Guan Yu + Zhang Fei.
- In battle: use Guan Yu and Zhang Fei aggressively against enemy generals. Their dueling skills are excellent. Protect your militia line while the heroes flank.
- After capturing Dong, move to **Puyang** or **Taishan** — your second province target.

Economy

- Build farms in every new settlement. Food surplus = public order = growth.
- Keep at least one building slot for public order (temples or garrisons).

Diplomacy

- By now, one neighboring faction may have declared war. Don't panic — they usually want a weak settlement. Offer a small payment for peace if you're not ready.
- Seek a **Coalition** or **Military Alliance** with Gongsun Zan or Kong Rong. A single ally deters multiple enemies.

Turn 6-10: Expand Carefully

Conquest Strategy

- Target **one direction only**. Don't fight on two fronts. If you're at war with Yuan Shao to the north and 陶 Qian to the south, make peace with one.
- Capture your second full commandery. This gives you a second building slot for income or recruitment.
- Do NOT take settlements you can't defend. Leave buffer territory between you and strong enemies.

Army Management

- You should have one main army (Liu Bei + Guan Yu + Zhang Fei). Do not hire a second general yet — the upkeep cost is too high.
- If a second enemy army appears, recruit a **garrison** in your capital (cheap militia). Don't create a second full army until you have two commanderies fully developed.

Economy Check (End of Turn 10)

- Food surplus: +5 minimum. If below, build more farms.
- Income: +500 minimum per turn. If below, build markets, sign more trade deals.
- Public order: All settlements above -5. Assign characters with "+public order" skills as administrators.

Reforms

- Research **Agricultural Reforms** (food) or **Taxation Reforms** (income) first. Military reforms can wait.

Turn 11-15: Stabilise & Prepare

Buildings

- Upgrade your capital to **Town** level (population 4) if you have the gold. This unlocks second-tier buildings and a garrison slot.
- Build a **Temple** or **Confucian School** in settlements with unrest. Public order is the cap on expansion speed.

Characters & Satisfaction

- Check every character's satisfaction. If anyone is below 60, give them an **Ancillary** (item), a **Court Position**, or an **Administrator** role.
- Recruit one or two new characters if you have open retinue slots. Look for characters with "+commerce" or "-corruption" traits.

Diplomacy Targets

- Identify your **first mid-game enemy**. On Normal, this is likely Yuan Shao (north) or Cao Cao (southwest).
- Build spy networks. Send a character with high cunning as a spy into your next target's court.

Turn 16-20: The First Crisis

What to Expect

- Around turn 15-20, your nearest major power will declare war or demand tribute. This is normal.
- Your public order may dip as your empire grows. Assign administrators and build temples.
- A random event (dilemma) will test your decision-making. Choose options that favour food or satisfaction.

Military Action

- If at war, fight defensively. Let the enemy attack your settlements so you fight on favourable terrain.
- In battle: use your generals to kill routing enemies (increases army XP). Keep the main force together.
- Consider recruiting a second army only if:
 - You have +10 food surplus
 - You have +1000 gold in reserve
 - You need to defend a second front

Goals Achieved by Turn 20

- 2-3 commanderies captured and stable
- Positive food and income
- At least one ally or coalition
- Core army: Liu Bei + Guan Yu + Zhang Fei, at least rank 3 each
- One spy placed in a rival court

Quick Reference

Turn	Priority Action
1	Trade agreements, move army south
2-3	Capture Dong Commandery
4-5	Build farms, secure first province
6-8	Expand in one direction only
9-10	Economy check: food +5, income +500
11-13	Upgrade capital, assign administrators
14-16	Diplomacy: choose next target
17-20	Defend first crisis, achieve stability

If Something Goes Wrong

- **Bankrupt?** Disband the most expensive unit(s). Cancel all diplomacy payments. Sell food for gold.
- **Attacked on two fronts?** Make peace with one side — pay them if needed. Your priority is to survive, not to win every war.
- **General assassinated?** Recruit a replacement from the pool. Any Vanguard or Commander can fill Guan Yu's role temporarily.
- **Revolts?** Lower taxes in the rebellious province. Build a temple. Assign a character with “+public order” there.

Wave 1 — The Kingdom Endures

Roleplaying Background

Years have passed. Your warlord now commands a stable domain — a true kingdom with borders, allies, and enemies. The world is no longer about survival but about expansion. Trade routes stretch across your lands. Your generals are seasoned veterans. But new threats gather at every border.

Your goal: secure your kingdom's future through diplomacy, strategy, and well-placed force.

Game Setup

Setting	Choice
Difficulty	Hard
Campaign	Rise of the Warlords
Faction	Any major regional power (e.g., Gongsun Zan, Yuan Shao, Liu Biao)
Turn Timer	Unlimited
Battle Time Limit	60 min

What's New

- **Graphics overhaul** — the world looks richer and more immersive
- **Content mods** — new units, buildings, and events
- **Audio pack** — thematic battle music
- **Mechanic mods** — deeper systems (may affect diplomacy, economy, or spies)

Strategy Shift

On Hard difficulty, the AI is more aggressive and makes smarter decisions. Read `02-strategy.md` for advanced tactics.

Mod List

Units Model Historical Reskin by harrylee95

v2.0.0

GRAPHICS

Historically-accurate reskin of Han faction unit models. Removes inconsistent vanilla designs with researched period-appropriate armor, weapons, and equipment.

Visual overhaul only. Safe to add mid-campaign.

New and Better Horse Armors for Generals by kailash

v1.2.0

GRAPHICS

High-quality horse armor textures for all general mounts. Includes unique barding for legendary horses like Red Hare and Dilu with period-accurate designs.

Recommended to pair with Horse Armor For Generals (base model mod) for best results.

Better Faces Plus by kailash

v1.1.0

GRAPHICS

Improves character face textures with adjusted skin tones, finer detail, and more natural proportions. Zero performance impact — texture sizes unchanged.

Works with all character mods including MTU and TUP. Safe to add anytime.

Horse Armor For Generals by kailash

v1.1.0

GRAPHICS

Adds 3D horse armor models to general mounts. Unique heavy cataphract armor for legendary characters, leather armor for standard generals. Visual enhancement only.

Pairs with New and Better Horse Armors for Generals for full texture fidelity.

More Horse Armor Variation and Color Variation by contactnovuspc

v2.1.0

GRAPHICS

Adds varied horse armor and color variations to most Northern cavalry units. Works in both Romance and Records modes for visual diversity.

Complements the general horse armor mods. Adds to cavalry units, not just generals.

Arrow Trails Redux by Petellius

v1.1.0

GRAPHICS

Enhances arrow and projectile trail visibility during battles. Makes volley behavior visually clear and dramatically improves the cinematic feel of ranged combat.

Visual-only enhancement. Safe to use with all mods.

More Flag Variations in Battle by contactnovuspc

v1.2.0

GRAPHICS

Adds varied banner and flag designs to units in battle. Improved visual distinction between retinues and more historically diverse army appearances.

Visual enhancement only. Safe mid-campaign.

Han Dynasty Brick Style Unit Cards by King of Wei

v1.6

UI

Redesigned unit cards using Han Dynasty brick carving art style. Beautiful period-appropriate aesthetic replacing vanilla unit portraits.

Purely cosmetic. Works with all unit mods.

Make Them Unique 3.3 by Wu Anguo

v3.3

CONTENT

Adds unique 3D models, portrait art, and custom abilities to over 100 generic and historical characters. The definitive character uniqueness mod for Three Kingdoms.

⚠ **Conflict:** TUP (Total Unique Pack) → Compatible — designed to work alongside TUP

⚙ Gives unique battlefield abilities and passives to previously generic characters

Requires a new campaign for full effect. Extremely popular and well-maintained.

MTU Characters Remodeled

by contactnovuspc

v1.3.0

CONTENT

Enhanced high-detail 3D models for MTU characters. Replaces MTU models with higher-poly, better-textured versions while maintaining the same art style.

Dependencies: Make Them Unique 3.3

Load BEFORE Make Them Unique in load order (Remodeled at top, MTU below). Compatible with all MTU submods.

MTU Event Add-on 1.0

by kailash

v1.0

CONTENT

Adds custom narrative events and dilemmas for MTU characters. Gives unique story moments for heroes added by Make Them Unique.

Dependencies: Make Them Unique 3.3

⚙️ Adds scripted events and dilemmas for unique characters

Recommended new campaign. Adds flavor and character-specific story beats.

Better Diplomacy

by kailash

v1.2.0

MECHANICS

Fine-tunes AI diplomacy behavior for more predictable and sensible negotiations. AI makes offers that reflect actual needs, values alliance commitments more, and avoids nonsensical trade demands.

⚙️ Adjusts AI negotiation weights and evaluation logic

No new campaign required. Safe mid-save.

Relationships Matter

by kailash

v1.7.2

MECHANICS

Enhances character friend/rival interactions with deeper relationship consequences. Friends provide stronger bonuses, rivalries escalate more dramatically, and Guanxi relationships feel impactful.

⚙️ Modifies character relationship satisfaction, loyalty, and event triggers

Works with MTU. V1.7.2 compatible.

Battlefield Conversations EXPANDED! [1.7.2]

by kailash

v1.7.2

CONTENT

Expands vanilla battlefield dialogue with hundreds of new lines across all character archetypes. Earth, Wood, Metal, Fire, and Water generals get unique taunts, battle cries, and flavor lines.

Purely audio/flavor. Compatible with all mods.

Power and Politics

by kailash

v1.5.0

MECHANICS

Adds unique political mechanics for every playable faction. Reworks influence, faction council dynamics, and internal politics. Gives each faction a distinct political playstyle.

⚙️ Replaces vanilla faction politics with unique per-faction political systems. Adds new court positions, political events, and power struggle mechanics.

Requires new campaign. Significant gameplay depth addition.

Han Character Hoarding Nerf

by Scicotheron

v1.0.0

MECHANICS

Removes the Han Empire's bonuses to character satisfaction and salary. Enables spying on the Han. Prevents the Han from hoarding every character in the mid-game.

⚙️ Reduces Han Empire satisfaction bonuses, enables player to compete for characters

Improves campaign pacing. Prevents Han Empire from becoming an unassailable character magnet.

Advanced Strategy for Wave 1

Campaign Strategy on Hard

Early Game (First 20 Turns)

1. **Secure your home commandery** — build the food chain first (farm > market > workshop)
2. **One army, one purpose** — don't split forces early; focus on one enemy at a time
3. **Diplomacy is defense** — use non-aggression pacts to protect flanks
4. **Spies in every court** — embed early, reap intelligence later

Mid Game (Turns 20-60)

1. **Two-front planning** — by now you have two armies; they should push opposite directions
2. **Governor assignments** — assign characters to rich commanderies for bonuses
3. **Reform priorities** — unlock administrative reforms before military ones
4. **Coalitions** — join or form one to deter large aggressors

Late Game (Turns 60+)

1. **Kingmaking** — once you become king, expect the “kingdom” diplomatic penalty
2. **Economic consolidation** — ensure every territory generates profit
3. **Elite armies** — replace militia with elite units as income allows
4. **The final push** — three kingdoms remain; choose your moment

Battle Tactics for Hard

- **AI uses flanking** — always reserve cavalry for counter-flanking
- **Moral shocks** — focus fire on enemy general; loss of general = route cascade
- **Terrain denial** — capture high ground before engaging
- **Siege patience** — build siege engines rather than assaulting walls directly
- **Retreat is an option** — preserve armies, fight another day

Building a Strong Economy

Your economy is the engine of your entire campaign. On Hard difficulty, the AI builds faster, fields more armies, and recovers from losses more quickly. You cannot out-fight them if you cannot out-earn them. A strong economy funds better troops, more construction, and more diplomatic leverage. A weak economy forces hard choices between a building and a dead general.

The Food-Income-Public Order Triangle

Every economic decision in Three Kingdoms trades off between three resources: food, income, and public order. An exhausted food surplus causes starvation and revolts. Weak income prevents army recruitment. Low public order spawns rebel armies. You can't maximise all three — you have to balance them.

Here is how to read your economy at a glance:

Stat	Healthy	Warning	Critical
Food Surplus	+10 to +30	+2 to +9	0 or below
Income Per Turn	+1000 or more	+300 to +999	Below +300
Public Order	0 or higher	-5 to -1	-6 or below
Corruption	Under 15%	15-25%	Over 25%
Treasury	3000+	1000-2999	Under 1000

When food drops: cancel all building queues in provinces that aren't already building farms. Start a farm immediately in every commandery that has an empty slot. Do not recruit new units — every unit costs food. If desperate, sell a non-food building and replace it with a farm.

When income drops: check corruption levels first (it's usually corruption). Drop the tax rate to normal if you raised it. Cancel trade agreements with factions that pay you less than 50 gold per turn and replace them with higher-value trade partners. Demolish redundant recruitment buildings.

When public order drops: assign a character with high authority or a "+public order" trait as administrator to the affected commandery. Build a temple or Confucian school. Lower taxes if empire-wide. Check for enemy spies (low public order in a stable province often means espionage).

Building a Trade Empire

Trade is the most efficient income source in Three Kingdoms because it scales without costing food. Every trade agreement generates gold per turn based on the resources in the connected commanderies. The more trade routes you have, the more each individual route is worth.

To maximise trade: 1. Build roads in every commandery. Roads determine whether a trade route exists at all. An unconnected commandery cannot trade. 2. Upgrade your capital's port. A tier-3 port generates vastly more trade income than a tier-1 port. 3. Sign trade agreements with everyone who will accept. Every agreement adds to your income and, importantly, to your trade network's value multiplier. 4. Conquer or ally with factions sitting on trade resource nodes (silk, spice, copper). These resources increase the value of all connected trade routes. 5. The commerce reform branch (green) multiplies trade income. Invest in it early — every turn of compound growth matters.

Trade route checklist each turn: - Are all trade slots full? If you have 3 of 4 slots filled, find a 4th partner immediately. - Are your trade partners rich? A trade partner with 5 settlements generates more gold than one with 1 settlement. Prioritise trade with larger factions. - Are your routes connected? If you conquer a settlement and the route breaks, rebuild the road or port immediately.

When to Expand vs When to Develop

New players tend to expand constantly. Experienced players know when to stop and develop. Every new commandery adds to your corruption pool, requires a garrison, and increases food consumption. Taking a commandery that is not yet profitable is a net loss.

Expand when: - Your food surplus is above 10 — you can absorb the consumption - Your income is above 1500 per turn — you can afford the building queue - The commandery has a valuable resource (horse, iron, copper, silk, spice, trade port) - You have a character ready to become administrator - You can defend it with armies already in the region

Develop when: - Your food surplus is below 5 — you need to stabilise - Your income is under 500 per turn — you cannot afford to build in new territory - Your public order is negative in any existing commandery — unrest spreads to neighbouring provinces - You have empty building slots in existing commanderies — those are free income left on the table

A simple rule: after conquering a commandery, build a farm and a garrison immediately. Wait five turns. If public order is positive and food is healthy, you can afford the next expansion.

Corruption: The Empire Tax

Corruption is the single biggest threat to a large economy. It increases with every commandery you own, peaking at around 50% income reduction for massive empires. Every 10 commanderies roughly adds 8-12% corruption if unchecked.

How to fight corruption: 1. Assign an administrator to every commandery. Administrators reduce corruption by 15-25% in their commandery based on their skills. A Sentinel or Commander with corruption-reduction traits can add another 5-10%. 2. Research governance reforms. The purple branch has nodes that reduce corruption by 5-10% across the entire empire. These stack. 3. Build state workshops and granaries. These specific buildings reduce corruption in their commandery and provide industry/food income. 4. Recruit characters with the “Incorruptible” or “Honest” trait. Assign them as administrators to your wealthiest commanderies. 5. Use vassals instead of direct conquest for poor territories. A vassal pays tribute without increasing your corruption.

At 10+ commanderies: expect 20-40% corruption. By this point, you should have governance reforms half-done and an administrator in every commandery. If you don't start fighting corruption before empire size 8, you'll be playing catch-up for the rest of the campaign.

Food Economy: Feeding Your War Machine

Food is consumed by every army, every settlement with population, and every unit you recruit. It's the one resource you can't generate from thin air — you need farms.

Food sources by value: 1. Farms (tier 1-3) — the only dedicated food building. Build one in every commandery. 2. Resource settlements — fishing ports and rice paddies on the campaign map add food. 3. Granaries — administrative building that adds food + reduces corruption. Late-game staple. 4. Reforms — the yellow reform branch adds +2/+4 food per turn from farms.

Food consumption by unit: - Militia: 1 food per turn (per full unit, not per soldier) - Professional: 2 food per turn - Elite: 3 food per turn - Each general in an army: 2 food per turn

A full stack of 18 elite units costs about 40-50 food per turn just to exist. With three armies, you're spending 120-150 food per turn before building consumption. That's why mid-game food collapses happen — you upgrade your armies without upgrading your farms.

Avoiding a food collapse: - Every time you upgrade a unit (militia → professional → elite), count the additional 1 food cost - Before recruiting a second or third army, ensure your food surplus is 15+ - Build tier-2 farms after capturing 4+ commanderies, tier-3 after 8+ - Never demolish a farm without having a replacement ready

Specialised Commandery Strategy

Not every commandery should be built the same way. Specialise based on resources:

- **Farm commandery** (rice paddies, fishing): build farms + granary + temple. Feed the empire.
- **Industry commandery** (iron, copper): build workshops + state workshop + armourer. Fund the empire and produce weapons.
- **Commerce commandery** (silk, spice, ports): build markets + port + roads. Generate trade wealth.
- **Military commandery** (horses, border regions): build garrison + military buildings. Recruit and defend.
- **Administrative commandery** (capital): build your best buildings + highest-tier garrison. Assign your best administrator.

A specialised commandery produces 30-50% more in its role than a generalised one. By the mid-game, you should have at least one of each type.

Economic Timing: When to Spend and When to Save

Early game (turns 1-30): Spend everything. Every 100 gold should go to farms, markets, or roads. Gold sitting in your treasury earns no interest. The only reason to save early is if you're about to recruit a general.

Mid game (turns 30-80): Save 2000-4000 gold in reserve. Unexpected events (dilemmas, bribes, war declarations) cost gold. Keep a buffer. Spend the rest on building upgrades and professional army recruitment.

Late game (turns 80+): Save 8000+ gold in reserve. Endgame crises trigger expensive dilemmas. You may need to buy alliances, bribe factions for peace, or rapidly recruit an emergency army. Gold is the ultimate insurance policy against a campaign-ending disaster.

Intermediate Systems (Phase 2 Training)

Court & Government

- **Faction Leader, Heir, and Prime Minister** give powerful faction-wide bonuses. Appoint carefully — don't leave these slots empty.
- Assign characters to court positions based on their **traits and skills**, not just loyalty. A corrupt administrator hurts more than a disloyal one.
- Government type affects available court positions and satisfaction distribution. **Meritocracy** and **Patriarchy** have very different trade-offs.

Guanxi — The Relationship System

Guanxi is the web of personal relationships between your characters. It's Three Kingdoms' most innovative system and the key to long-term campaign stability.

Relationship Types:

Type	How It Forms	Effect
Friendship	Same army, successful battles, positive events	+satisfaction, +battle performance when together
Sworn Brotherhood	Event chain (costs gold, requires high relationship)	Permanent +satisfaction, unbreakable loyalty pair
Rivalry	Opposing traits, competition for positions, negative events	-satisfaction, -battle performance when together
Hatred	Escalated rivalry or event-driven	Severe penalties. One may betray the other.
Marriage	Diplomacy (join families) or character events	Binds two families. Children inherit traits.
Adoption	Character event — recruit a young hero	Instant family member + loyalty

Managing Guanxi:

- **Pair friends, separate rivals.** Check the character details panel for relationship icons before assigning generals to the same army. Friends give each other +3-5 satisfaction per turn. Rivals cancel that out and more.
- **Sworn brotherhood is expensive but permanent.** The event costs around 2000-4000 gold depending on character rank. It's worth it for your core generals — they will never defect.
- **Marriage is a political tool.** Marry a talented but disloyal general into your family — family members get massive satisfaction bonuses. Marriage also creates diplomatic alliances with the target faction.

- **Children inherit traits.** Marry two characters with “+satisfaction” or “-corruption” traits and their child may inherit those traits. Long-term dynasty planning matters.
- **Divorce is possible** but comes with severe satisfaction penalties. Only use it if the alternative is a civil war.

Guanxi Events (with MTU Event Add-on):

With the MTU Event Add-on installed, unique characters generate additional relationship events: duels of honour, rescue missions, betrayal dilemmas, and family feuds. These add narrative depth and force you to make choices that ripple through your character web.

Character Development – Skills, Traits & Ancillaries

Skill Trees:

Every character has a skill tree with 10-15 nodes. Plan their development:

Class	Priority Skills	Why
Commander	+satisfaction (all), army movement, replenishment	Keeps your empire stable. Your faction-wide loyalty beacon.
Vanguard	Charge bonus, cavalry buffs, +damage	Field general. Put them in charge of your cavalry army.
Champion	Melee evasion, duelling, +health	General killer. Send them against enemy champions.
Strategist	Ranged damage, fire arrows, cunning	Spy network and artillery support. Never leave home without one.
Sentinel	Melee defence, garrison, -corruption	Best administrator. Put them in your richest province.

Traits:

Characters gain and lose traits based on their actions. A general who wins many battles gains “+morale” traits. One who loses gets “-satisfaction” traits. A character who sits idle gains “Complacent” (-satisfaction).

- **Positive traits to recruit for:** Diligent, Resolute, Inspiring, Generous, Cunning
- **Negative traits to avoid:** Corrupt, Cruel, Timid, Complacent, Arrogant
- **Trait farming:** If you have a young heir, send them with your main army to every battle — they absorb positive combat traits. Assign them as administrator later for administrative traits.

Ancillaries:

Every character has 3 ancillary slots (weapon, armour, accessory). Fill all 3 on every character. Even common ancillaries give small bonuses that add up across 20+ characters.

- **Weapons:** +melee damage or +charge bonus for generals. Give your best weapon to your Vanguard or Champion.
- **Armour:** +melee defence or +health. Give to your frontline Sentinel or Commander.
- **Accessories:** +satisfaction, +cunning, or +commerce. Distribute based on role — satisfaction accessories go to disloyal but talented characters.
- **Trade for ancillaries** in diplomacy. Many factions will trade a decent weapon for 500-1000 gold or a food deal.
- **The Imperial Seals** (end-game) are the best ancillaries in the game. They grant faction-wide bonuses to prestige, satisfaction, and income. Fight for them.

Spies & Undercover Network

- Embed **spies** early. The best time to plant a spy is before you need one. By turn 30, you should have at least one spy in your nearest rival's court.
- Secure your spy's position by having them perform **small favours** (reveal army positions) before asking them to **assassinate or sabotage**.
- **Counter-intelligence matters.** Assign a character with high cunning as an administrator in each commandery to reveal enemy spies.
- A well-placed spy can steal technologies, incite rebellions, or assassinate a faction leader — often more valuable than an army.

Events & Dilemmas

Three Kingdoms throws dilemmas at you every few turns. These are not flavour text — they have real mechanical consequences.

Dilemma Type	Typical Choice	Consequence
Food vs Gold	Give food to starving region or sell it	Public order vs short-term cash
Character Conflict	Side with general A or general B	The loser loses satisfaction, may defect
Diplomatic Crisis	Bow to demand or refuse	War vs temporary stability
Succession	Choose your heir	The unchosen heir loses satisfaction
Reform Decision	Rush a reform or invest in stability	Tech advantage vs empire health

Dilemma strategy: - **Choose food and satisfaction** over money in the early game. Gold is temporary; revolts and defections are permanent. - **Never side against your best general** unless the alternative is worse. Losing a rank 6+ Champion to defection can cost you a campaign. -

Diplomatic dilemmas: buy time. If a powerful faction demands something, give it to them. You can take it back when you're stronger.

Reforms Tree

- Prioritize reforms that match your playstyle. Do not research randomly — every turn spent on the wrong reform is a turn of lost advantage.

- **Administrative reforms** (corruption reduction, satisfaction) scale better than military reforms for most campaigns.
- **Commerce reforms** compound over time. Invest early.
- Unlocking **purple (Governance)** and **green (Commerce)** tree nodes early gives a stronger economy foundation for late-game military pushes.

Army Composition

- A **balanced army** (frontline + ranged + cavalry) beats pure stacks every time.
 - 4-6 spear infantry (frontline)
 - 4-6 ranged units (archers/crossbows)
 - 2-4 cavalry (flanking)
 - 2-4 shock infantry or special units
- Learn counter units: **spears beat cavalry, cavalry beats ranged, ranged beats infantry, shock infantry beats spears.**
- Keep at least one **Strategist** in your main army for their formation abilities and ranged buffs.
- As your economy grows, phase out militia units for **professional** ones — the stat difference is significant by mid-game.

Training Exercises

1. Play as **Cao Cao** (best diplomatic tools) and focus on vassals + credibility.
2. Deliberately use spies to dismantle one enemy faction from the inside.
3. Build at least two specialized armies (e.g., one defensive, one aggressive cavalry).

Success criteria: Maintain high satisfaction across your empire. Use diplomacy + spies as effectively as armies.

Wave 2 — Beneath a Crimson Banner

Roleplaying Background

The empire burns. You are no longer a warlord or a king — you are the last hope of a dying age. Your territories stretch across China, but every border is contested. Generals scheme for your throne. The people grow restless. Three kingdoms stand between you and ultimate dominion, and the world itself seems to conspire against you.

This is the final wave. There is no backup plan. No retreat. Only victory or annihilation.

Your goal: unite China under your banner — or watch it all burn.

Game Setup

Setting	Choice
Difficulty	Legendary
Campaign	Mandate of Heaven
Faction	Any (recommend a faction you know well from Waves 0-1)
Turn Timer	Unlimited
Battle Time Limit	60 min

What's New

- **Full mechanical overhauls** — diplomacy, economy, and characters work differently
- **Endgame crisis events** — scripted challenges that test your empire
- **Maximum difficulty** — Legendary AI morale bonuses, no battle saves

- **Compatibility considerations** — some Wave 1 mods conflict; read carefully

The Challenge

Wave 2 is designed for players who have mastered Waves 0-1. If you haven't completed at least one campaign on Hard with Wave 1's modset, consider playing more before starting this wave.

Mod List

Radious Total War Mod - Part 1 by Radious

v3.1.0

MECHANICS

Comprehensive total overhaul for Three Kingdoms — Part 1. Transforms every aspect of the game: economy, population, buildings, unit rosters, technology, diplomacy, and AI. Requires Part 2.

Dependencies: Radious Total War Mod - Part 2

⚙️ Complete overhaul of all game systems. New economic model with population, revised building chains, expanded unit rosters, rebalanced tech tree, smarter AI. Double unit sizes.

REQUIRES A NEW CAMPAIGN. Download both Part 1 and Part 2. Radious includes its own bug fixes — do NOT use 1.7.2 Bug Fix alongside it.

Radious Total War Mod - Part 2 by Radious

v3.1.0

MECHANICS

Part 2 of the Radious Total War overhaul. Contains additional assets, unit models, and script files. Required alongside Part 1 for full functionality.

Dependencies: Radious Total War Mod - Part 1

Load Part 2 after Part 1 in load order.

Radious + Make Them Unique Compatibility Patch by Radious

v1.0.0

MECHANICS

Official compatibility patch between Radious Total War Mod and Make Them Unique. Ensures MTU characters retain their unique models, abilities, and traits within the Radious overhaul.

Dependencies: Radious Total War Mod - Part 1, Radious Total War Mod - Part 2, Make Them Unique 3.3

Only needed if using MTU alongside Radious. Load after both Radious parts and MTU.

Make Them Unique 3.3 by Wu Anguo

v3.3

CONTENT

Adds unique 3D models, portrait art, and custom abilities to over 100 generic and historical characters. Included in Wave 2 for use with Radiums via the compatibility patch.

⚙️ Gives unique battlefield abilities and passives to previously generic characters

Included alongside Radiums for the full experience. Use the Radiums + MTU Compatibility Patch.

MTU Characters Remodeled

by contactnovuspc

v1.3.0

CONTENT

Enhanced high-detail 3D models for MTU characters. Requires MTU base mod.

Dependencies: Make Them Unique 3.3

Load BEFORE Make Them Unique in load order.

100% Matched Combat Mod (Units and Heroes)

by Der Grillachs

v1.1.0

MECHANICS

Changes combat to classic 1v1 matched combat from older Total War games. Units seek individual opponents instead of blob fighting. Heroes duel single enemies. Creates cinematic battle lines.

⚙️ Modifies unit collision, target selection, and combat AI to prefer 1v1 engagements

Best experienced with large unit sizes. Complements Radiums' double unit sizes perfectly.

Way of the Sword - Cinematic Combat

by Der Grillachs

v1.1.0

MECHANICS

Adds cinematic combat animations and camera techniques. Longer, more dramatic kill animations, sweeping camera movements during engagements, and Wushu-inspired choreography.

Visual enhancement for battle sequences. Works alongside Matched Combat Mod.

Kelstr's Realistic Battle Blood [1.7.X]

by Kelstr

v1.7.x

GRAPHICS

Drastically improved blood decals on the ground during and after battles. Characters and terrain accumulate realistic blood splatter based on combat intensity.

Graphical enhancement only. No performance impact. Complements the cinematic battle theme.

Expert Strategy for Wave 2

Campaign Strategy on Legendary

The First 50 Turns (Survival)

1. **Legendary AI cheats** — AI gets public order and morale bonuses. Plan for it.
2. **No battle saves** — every battle matters. Auto-resolve is more punishing.
3. **Aggressive expansion in the first 20 turns** — cripple your nearest rival before they grow
4. **Accept that you will lose settlements** — plan to retake, not to hold everything

Mod-Overhauled Systems

Diplomacy Overhaul

- The overhaul mod changes negotiation to a offer-demand system
- You must offer something of value for every request
- Trust is a resource — breaking treaties permanently damages relationships
- War declarations require casus belli or heavy diplomatic penalties

Economy Overhaul

- Population mechanics: larger cities drain food, generate wealth but require more public order
- Tax rate affects population growth — high taxes slow growth
- Trade route banditry: invest in road infrastructure to protect trade

Character Overhaul

- Generals have loyalty factions — they may rebel with their entire army
- Court politics matter: promote talented generals or risk defection
- Family tree management is critical — succession crises can end campaigns

Endgame Crisis Events

- **Horde armies** spawn from ungarded borders — keep reserve forces
- **Economic collapses** trigger when corruption reaches thresholds — reform down
- **Dilemmas** force choices between short-term gain and long-term stability
- **Rival kingdoms** coordinate against the player — divide and conquer

Battle Tactics for Legendary

- **Never autoresolve** against equal or greater forces — the calculator is ruthless
- **General sniping** is harder (AI protects generals better) — use cavalry traps
- **Morale management** is key — your units will break faster without your general nearby
- **Terrain is your only advantage** — always fight on favorable ground
- **Withdraw from unwinnable battles** — preserving armies is preserving campaign viability

Advanced Campaign Mastery (Phase 3)

Emperor Mechanics

- Once you declare yourself **Emperor** (or another faction does), the game shifts. You gain access to **Imperial Seals** — powerful ancillaries that grant faction-wide bonuses.
- Seals are awarded for achieving prestige milestones. Prioritize prestige generation once you control 60+ territories.
- The **Three Kingdoms** phase triggers when three factions reach King or Emperor status. At this point, the two rival emperors become permanent enemies.

Vassals vs Direct Conquest

- **Vassals** are useful buffers — they guard borders and contribute armies — but they generate less income than directly owned territories.
- Use vassals for regions with different culture (e.g., Nanman territories) where public order would be a nightmare.
- Direct conquest is better for wealthy commanderies with your culture. Vassalize the poor ones.
- You can **integrate** vassals later, but it takes time and satisfaction penalties. Plan your integration order.

Satisfaction & Corruption at Scale

- At large empire size (10+ commanderies), **corruption** eats 30-50% of your income if unchecked. Prioritize corruption-reducing reforms and buildings.
- **Satisfaction management** becomes a full-time job. Every turn, check your character list — anyone below 50 satisfaction needs an immediate promotion, ancillary, or marriage.
- Use **Administrators** in every commandery — they reduce corruption and increase income enough to justify their salary.
- The **Prime Minister** position is critical at this stage. Assign your highest-ranking character with “+satisfaction to all” traits.

Character Skill Trees

- By Phase 3, your core generals should be rank 6+. Plan their skill trees:
 - **Commanders:** Focus on “+satisfaction to all” and army movement range.
 - **Vanguards:** Damage and charge bonuses. They are your field generals.
 - **Champions:** Personal dueling skills and unit buffs.
 - **Strategists:** Ranged damage, formation abilities, and cunning for spy networks.
 - **Sentinels:** Defense, garrison bonuses, and administrator skills.
- Do not waste skill points on redundant abilities. Specialize each general for their role.

Timing Major Wars

- Do not declare yourself Emperor until you have 3+ elite armies ready. The diplomatic penalty with everyone else is severe — expect coalitions to form against you.
- Break alliances and coalitions **before** declaring war. The trust penalty is worth avoiding the “ally joined enemy” problem.
- Time your wars when your target is already fighting someone else. Let them exhaust their armies, then strike.

Training Exercises

1. Play a full campaign where you deliberately become Emperor as late as possible while still dominating the map.
2. Run a “tall” campaign (few high-quality commanderies) vs a “wide” campaign (rapid expansion).
3. Master the **Yellow Turban** or **Nanman** factions for completely different playstyles.

Success criteria: Reliably win on Hard/Very Hard. Understand *why* the AI makes certain diplomatic moves.

Battle Mastery & Micro (Phase 4)

Focus Areas

- **Terrain usage:** Forests block line of sight and reduce missile damage. Hills give morale and damage bonuses. Rivers slow movement and exhaust units. Choke points negate numerical disadvantages.

- **Flanking:** A unit attacking an enemy from the side or rear deals massive morale damage. One flanking cavalry charge can route an entire unit.
- **Cycle charging:** Charge, pull back, charge again. Cavalry that stays in melee loses its charge bonus. Micro your cavalry for maximum impact.
- **Hero duels (Romance mode):** Duels can swing battles instantly. Send your champion against enemy generals but pull them back when outmatched. In Records mode, general bodyguards are powerful but not invincible — use them as heavy cavalry.
- **Strategist abilities:** Fire arrows, smoke screens, and night battles are force multipliers. Use them.
- **Army stances:** March (faster but cannot retreat), Ambush (invisible until attack), Raiding (sustain without supply), and Forced March (extra range but exhausted in battle). Use the right stance for the situation.

Training Method

1. Replay the same historical battle (e.g., Guandu-style scenarios) multiple times with different army compositions.
2. Practice fighting 1.5x-2x larger armies on the battle map.
3. Watch high-level campaign battle footage and pause to analyze decisions.

Master Level — Legendary & Optimisation (Phase 5)

Legendary Difficulty Adjustments

- **No battle saves** — every battle matters. Auto-resolve is more punishing than manual battle.
- **AI morale bonuses** — enemy units take longer to break. Plan for extended fights.
- **AI public order cheats** — the AI expands faster without rebellion. Do not try to out-expand them — out-smart them.
- **Minimal reloading** — embrace mistakes. Legendary is about adaptation, not perfection.

Min-Maxing Your Empire

- **Character traits:** Recruit and promote characters with “+satisfaction,” “-corruption,” and “+commerce” traits. Remove or demote characters with negative traits.
- **Ancillaries:** Every character should have a full ancillary loadout. The bonuses compound. Trade for ancillaries in diplomacy if needed.
- **Court synergy:** Certain combinations of court positions + character traits create powerful synergies. For example, a Prime Minister with “+2 satisfaction to all” plus an Heir with “-10% corruption” nearly solves two problems at once.
- **Army specialisation:** By late game, build specialized armies — one for siege, one for field battles, one for rapid response. Don’t make every army a generalist.

Final Challenges

1. Win a Legendary campaign as a hard starting faction (Kong Rong, Liu Biao, or a Yellow Turban).
2. Unify China before turn 100 on Very Hard/Legendary.
3. Play a full campaign with self-imposed restrictions (no spies, no vassals, only one army type, etc.).

Learning Resources

Resource	Best For	Notes
Total War Academy (in-game / official site)	Phase 0-1	Official short videos
ItalianSpartacus YouTube	Phase 1-2	Excellent beginner campaign guides
Serious Trivia YouTube	Phase 2-4	Deep mechanical analysis
LegendofTotalWar	Phase 3-5	High-level Legendary campaigns
In-game Encyclopedia	All phases	Always keep it open

Suggested Campaign Progression

1. **Liu Bei or Sun Jian** (Normal) — learn the basics
2. **Cao Cao** (Hard) — learn diplomacy & manipulation
3. **Any faction you like** (Very Hard) — apply everything
4. **Hard starting faction** (Legendary) — master level

Appendices

Mod Installation Guide

Setup & Installation Guide

Total War Mod Manager (TWMM)

TW Mod Manager is the recommended tool for managing Total War: Three Kingdoms mods.

Download & Install

1. Visit <https://www.nexusmods.com/site/mods/1238>
2. Download the latest version
3. Run the installer
4. On first launch, point TWMM to your Total War: Three Kingdoms installation folder (typically steamapps/common/Total War THREE KINGDOMS)

Importing a Modlist

Each wave directory contains a `mods.yaml` file listing all mods and their sources.

1. Download each mod from its Nexus/Steam Workshop URL
2. Place `.pack` files in `Total War THREE KINGDOMS/data/`
3. Open TWMM — it scans the data folder and lists all detected mods
4. Check the mods you want to enable for your current wave
5. Arrange load order (see below)

Load Order Rules

1. **Dependencies before dependents** — if Mod B needs Mod A, Mod A loads first
2. **UI mods load last** — UI changes should override everything else
3. **Audio mods load before content mods** — prevents conflicts
4. **Total overhauls load first** — they change the foundation everything else builds on

TWMM allows drag-and-drop reordering. Use the “Groups” feature to save load order profiles for each wave.

Verifying Compatibility

- TWMM checks for known conflicts and shows warnings
- Cross-reference with `conflicts.yaml` for tracked issues
- If TWMM shows a conflict, check the resolution field in the mod entry or `conflicts.yaml`

Per-Wave Profiles

1. In TWMM, create a “Wave 0” group with those mods enabled and all others disabled
2. When moving to Wave 1, disable all Wave 0 mods first, then enable Wave 1 mods
3. This prevents cross-wave conflicts

Manual Installation (Without TWMM)

1. Download mod .pack files
2. Place in `steamapps/common/Total War THREE KINGDOMS/data/`
3. Launch the game launcher
4. Go to “Mod Manager” tab
5. Enable mods in the correct order
6. Launch the game

“Note: The game’s built-in mod manager is less capable than TWMM. TWMM is strongly recommended.”